The Long Arm of the Lord

A personal conversion story

David West

Chapter 1

Turning Point

It was going to be just another afternoon in Malta, which, no doubt would be followed by another evening with my friends, drinking, talking and wasting more time; enjoying myself but doing nothing in particular with my life. Perhaps we would drop into the casino or see a film tonight. Who knows, but right then, I was sitting on the sofa while my mother and grandmother sat in front of the fire, talking.

Just how I joined the conversation, I am not sure, but my mother and I began one of our usual arguments. Our positive feelings were rarely shared and we both had a mutual, mistrust of each other. Tonight, my mood was particularly dark and brooding. Depressed and dangerously angry with myself, I struck out at her with stinging words. I had returned to Malta, bored by my job in the City of London where I had been articled to a firm of Chartered accounts. Was it her fault? No. But behind the frustration with my boring job was the resentment at my mother's infidelity to my father. I blasted my disinterest with life and my hatred of hypocrisy in carefully chosen words which hurt

without being obvious. Words flew between us like sparks in a fire becoming hotter and more careless with every exchange. Mum was getting more and more agitated and I could see this arguing was doing no good to anyone.

I got up and left, without looking back, and began to climb the stairs to my room. Then it happened, the moment that changed everything and was eventually to change me, my world and my life from then on.

Before I had even reached the top of the stairs, my grandmother's voice shrieked "David! Your mother has fainted!"

I rushed back down and entered the room to see mum, sprawled out on the floor. In seconds, I was there, my arms under her and lifting her limp body onto the sofa. I still cannot understand how I found the strength to pick her up but I did it with no problem at all.

My grandmother rushed off to phone for a doctor and I was left bending over my mother's unconscious body. Memories flooded my mind. From the day I had learnt that she had a lover, my mother and I had rarely managed to talk to each other. I felt sorry for dad and had become very unforgiving and intolerant. It stung me to know I had often eaten and gone clay pigeon shooting with the other man and in fact was quite fond of him before I knew the truth. My religious convictions were few and rather superficial but I had often prayed for a reconciliation between my parents.

The doctors arrived and confirmed my worst fears. She had had a massive stroke and knowing her history of heart attacks, the doctors were not feeling confident. I heard one of them whisper to his colleague. "There is not much hope for her".

I was deeply upset and a terrible anger rose up inside

me. In my heart I turned with complete honesty to addressed the God I hardly knew.

"I have begged you to bring them together," I said, "You have done nothing. Now I can never believe in you"

This was not a threat or ultimatum, but a sad statement of what I saw to be true.

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Chapter 2

Accident

This story had its beginning much further back. It was the 28th April 1938 and I was about to be born. At the same time, the world was teetering on the edge of a new war. Over in China and Japan, things were getting out of hand. Just 10 months before, in July 1937, Japan had invaded mainland China and things were beginning to unravel in those parts. Over in Germany, the fascists were showing their darker side and it was becoming obvious that a storm was brewing. In Malta, however, life continued on as usual with no knowledge of the dark cloud that would soon overshadow the island.

It would seem I nearly did not make it here at all since six years before I was born, I nearly lost one of my parents. My father was a draughtsman and worked at the Malta Dry Docks. During his free time, he was an amateur footballer and was considered one of the best on the island. Even now, more than half a century later, he is still written about. He played for Floriana football club and was such a fast runner, his team-mates called him 'The Gazelle'. The supporters gave him the name, 'Gentleman George West' because he

was never known to have fouled anyone. The club would send a car to collect him from our home in Pieta and on one particular day, the cab turned up but with a new driver. The man drove like a maniac and, later it was discovered that he was in fact drunk. As they were nearing the entrance to Porte des Bombes, the inevitable happened, the car went out of control, careering into a wall, killing the driver instantly and catapulting my father through the windscreen and into the gardens beyond. An ambulance was passing by on the other side of the road and, as it happened, it contained my mother on her way to the hospital to deliver my elder sister Irene. Dad was unconscious and lay in a coma for ten days. His jaw was broken, all his teeth were smashed and his lower gums had been damaged beyond repair. His face healed, and the scars all but disappeared. However, the accident had a permanent effect on his personality. My mother said he was never the same after that and I often wonder if the experience of coming so close to death had much to do with it. It may be that he experienced more during that episode than he let on. From then on nothing seemed to worry him too much and mum often complained that he had no ambition and she got annoyed that he did not take charge of anything. She had to become the leader of the family though he was happy to do his fair share of work both in bringing in the finances and working around the home. I can never remember him saying an unkind word about anyone. He had a cheerful, positive outlook on life and did not seem to feel physical pain as much as other people. I cannot remember him moaning or complaining about anything. When I look back on it, I now realise that this made me very protective towards him.

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Chapter 3

Birth and War

Six years after the accident, I was about to be born. My mother was in labour and the doctors were worried. As a young child, she had contracted Rheumatic Fever and although she had survived it, it had left her with a damaged heart and some other life-long side effects that could possibly effect a pregnancy. I was the last of her four children, all of whom had been born safe and well. However, earlier in this pregnancy complications had set in and were becoming life-threatening. The doctors advised her not to continue with the pregnancy as, if she did, it was likely that she or her baby could die. She carried full term but now, during the labour, the contractions were not bringing about the desired effect and, as the doctors had told her, there was a real chance that one or both of us would not make it through. God's hand however, guided the event and both mother and baby did just fine.

Many years later, my wife told me a nearly identical story about her own birth. The midwife in that scenario had berated her mother in the fourth month for allowing the pregnancy to continue because of a serious complication.

Her mother, being a committed Catholic, had continued and both mother and baby were perfectly well.

For now, all was well and running smoothly in our typical Mediterranean household. We lived in Pieta, close to Floriana and the city of Valletta. For the next year and five months, it seems all was pretty normal but, on the 3rd September, 1939, Britain declared war on Germany and Malta, being a British colony, was suddenly at war.

The first change that took place in our household was that my father was called up to active duty with the KINGS OWN MALTA REGIMENT.

The historic bombing of the tiny island of Malta did not, in fact, start at that date. According to an account taken from the book "Malta Magnificent", written in Malta by Anthony Gerard, in 1942, it was not till Italy joined the war on the 10th of June, 1940 that the attacks began, albeit, very half-heartedly. Many families in Malta were in an awkward position because they had Italian connections. Our family was solidly English and escaped this rather painful dilemma. However, we did not escape the flying bombs that came our way as Hitler sent his Luftwaffe to take over the job of subduing this tricky little Island.

I was barely two years of age and, as it happened, we were living in one of the key target areas of Malta. Inevitably, our house was hit. My older sisters tell me that they were left standing in the shell of the basement of our home as the upper floors collapsed around them. They were lucky, many people in Malta died in their cellar shelters. My family climbed out through a huge opening which had appeared as they stood, backs against the wall which shielded them.

We moved from place to place and, in all, lost five houses. In one of these bombing events, our maid picked me

up and ran with me down the cellar steps. She was not to survive the raid unhurt. The blast threw her violently, irrevocably damaging both of her legs as she was knocked unconscious. Eventually, the family came looking for her and me, her charge. I was told that they were happy but astonished to find me hanging, quite unhurt, on a hook on the wall which had caught onto my toddler clothes.

I do believe now that God's hand was noticeable in each of these events. My father was now Captain George West and stationed in Siggiewi in the south of the island. The rest of the family, my mother, myself and my three sisters, eventually moved to Gozo, the small island next to Malta. Once we were in Gozo it was slightly safer but, even there, people had to be careful not to be outdoors too long since the bombers often swooped down low over the fields and fired on anyone who was visible.

It is strange though that, my memory of these important times is nearly blank. I often wonder why. Only small snippets appear, like being treated for pains in my leg by the local doctor who thought I may have polio but this was not so.

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Chapter 4

Life in Sliema

When the bombing stopped around 1943, I was five years old and we returned to Malta to live in a Sliema town house in what was then called 'Victoria Avenue'. We lived in number 20 and across the road, about 200 meters away, from George Borg Olivier who became prime minister of Malta. The street has now been re-named after him

The war finally ended two years later and people started to relax. However, it was on the seafront in Sliema that another very close shave happened in my childhood. I was now about seven or eight years of age and my elder sister, Grace, and I were walking along the flat rocky seafront. Grace spotted a rope, covered in seaweed draped over the rocks. She bent down and took hold of it and started pulling it to see what was attached at the other end. Meanwhile, I went to look and heard a soft ticking noise. I shouted at her "It's a bomb Grace. I'm going!" Grace laughed "Don't be so silly," she said, thinking I was being dramatic and imagining things. I was not waiting to be

proven correct so I said "Bye then, I'm going", and walked off.

Grace had no choice, she was in charge of me and had to drop the rope and chase after me. As we left some boys, who were playing on the beach took up the game and started playing with the rope. As we reached near to home, we heard a loud blast. It was not till the next day, that we learned that the three boys had been killed instantly by the explosion.

Life gradually returned to normal. I remember going with dad to the stadium every Saturday afternoon to watch his team play their main rivals. We would sit on the side of the supporters of Floriana and I could hear people whisper his name and greet him. In the evenings we would often go to visit his mother, who lived not far away, and they would play cribbage while I would sit and talk to my uncle who was not so fond of playing cards. I felt at peace there and enjoyed their company. Granny West baked the best rice pudding ever!

One of the things I remember vividly from my early years was my ability to watch and enjoy someone at work. We lived in a street which housed many of the better off families. However, round the corner, not a hundred metres away, was a tiny room in which a cobbler sat repairing shoes.

He seemed to expect me to turn up and just smiled when I did. I would watch him put the shoe on the last, cover the sole in a thick glue and then place a piece of leather on it. Next the leather was cut to the proper shape and secured. Not sure if he used nails or sewed them. A lovely picture of the Sacred Heart of Jesus hung behind where he sat and I would watch for many minutes without a

word being said. Somehow this man exuded peace and I felt he really enjoyed doing what he did.

I certainly found joy in watching him and to this day many years later, I can still imagine him sitting there with a smile on his face.

I adored my mum, and was very affectionate towards her but I spent quite a lot of time with my Dad. As well as going to his football club or his mothers, from a young age he and I would go to see films together. This carried on even when I was going through difficult times later in life. However, he rarely talked about himself, if ever. All I knew about him came from people who told me what a great handsome sportsman he was.

He was such a fast runner that he was given the nickname by his team 'The Gazelle' and because he was known never to have fouled anyone he was called 'Gentleman George West'.

Dad was always keen to promote a love of sports in all his children. My sister Marian, would often talk about how he would grab her by the hand and run with her when she was about eight years old. Later she turned out to be a very keen tennis player. My sister Irene was not so enthusiastic. Dad took her along to watch the football matches in Floriana but, from their seat, right in the front, all she could think about was how she would dodge the ball if it came towards her. It wasn't quite her thing. I was different. Me and my friends called ourselves 'The Sharp Shooters' and we met and played football near our home in Victoria Avenue. Dad decided that we should have a proper club room so he helped by kitting out our cellar with benches and other bits and pieces. We all wore the same T-shirts and our 'training' consisted of races round the block and high jumps over hurdles which dad created with bamboo rods.

At this time all seemed well with the world. I never noticed the oddity of my parent's relationship. The fact was, they were living separate lives in the same house. My father had his own room on the top floor and my mother in the main bedroom. As far as I can remember, I never went anywhere with them together. Nonetheless, I was a normal, happy kid even if a bit more mischievous than most.

Being the long awaited boy in a family of three girls did mean I was rather spoilt and, being the adventurous child that I was, I took full advantage of this. I tended to be a bit wild and I somehow managed to get thrown out of four or five junior schools. At one, I climbed through a window and went home for being told off for turning up in football boots, sporting a hockey stick. At another, the military school in St. Andrew's, I was put over a teacher's knee for a well-deserved spanking, whereupon I promptly bit her! Despite this behaviour, I was a well liked child; especially with our neighbours.

In the house next door to us, lived a family of seven , brothers and sisters, none of whom were married. They would join my father on the roof and chat away for a few hours. They lived a very reclusive life and were all deeply committed to their faith. One of the brothers enjoyed making large kites out of bamboo and crepe paper which he would give me and I would fly them for hours from our roof. Another member of the family was called Johnnie and whenever I met him in the street, he would give me a considerable amount of money, three or four Maltese pounds, equivalent today to around 50 euros.. Regrettably, I took advantage of this and would go out to meet him when I saw him. Every time he would ask me to tell my parents about it but I hardly ever did.

A Russian friend of the family, who I called Aunt Milla,

would turn up for tea every other day on her way to see her Russian friends around the corner and give me a 'big penny' to go and buy some classic comics. That was two shillings and sixpence which was also a lot in those days.

Up the road was a wonderful spinster who jokingly called me a scruffy little boy and threw me the equivalent of five pounds in today's money to go and have a haircut.

I also delighted in selling things for other people, making a huge commission. Occasionally this backfired especially in the case of five cocker spaniels which the children wanted back. I also collected all the old magazines like Vogue and Harper's ETC and sold them, second hand to a shop in the strand. I seemed to have a gift as a tradesman of sorts.

Regrettably for me, all this came to a bitter end when I was sent to St. Edwards college and imprisoned, or so it felt, at least for the first two years.

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Two years earlier, when I was 11 years old, my sister Grace died, but not as the r

Chapter 5

Death of Grace

Esult of an accident. She'd had appendicitis and had been operated on, successfully so we all thought. But a few months later, she died after much pain and illness which she tried to keep from everyone. I have since learnt that this is a 'million to one' occurrence caused by 'abdominal adhesion'. So rare in fact, that most doctors rule it out when presented with abdominal pain occurring months, or even years, after an appendectomy. This event took all the family by storm. She was a bright, vivacious and loving teenager, loved by all, especially her brother.

Where was God in all this you might ask. To the best of my knowledge our family was not a very religious one. We were indeed practising Catholics and we shared in the collective faith of an island that survived on prayers and faith during the war years. However I do not remember sharing this in any meaningful way with my parents. The death of Grace changed this. There was a new awareness of the need of His presence in our lives and dad and mum started going to mass more often. However, it was a quiet,

personal affair and not overly demonstrative. My Aunt Connie Fiteni, who would discuss religion openly at home was considered a bit too religious by our more reserved family but some of her ideas may have stayed somewhere in my mind. My grandfather, Joe Gat Rutter, on the other-hand, was deeply spiritual and it was he who took me for my confirmation ceremony. It was also his name, Joseph, that I took as my confirmation name; a name, as it happened, that would have significance to my future bride to be.

I was eleven when Grace died and the years that followed were lived with a blind sense of survival of whatever fate threw at me. Despite attending the most academically renowned school on the island, the Lyceum, I managed again to get sent home for three days. When I turned up, non-the-less, my parents decided to remove me permanently and sent me to be a full-time boarder at St.Edward's college in Cottonera. This was part of the British Public school system and was founded by Lord Strickland.

It was during my time at the college that I discovered that, the man with whom I enjoyed going hunting, who used to join my mother and I for lunch at home while my father was at work and with whom my mother and I would spend many evenings at his home, was, in fact, her lover. The revulsion that I felt is still painful to remember. I felt totally betrayed and also felt guilty and ashamed, since I had actually been fond of that other man.

From that time on, I was at war with mum and, for that matter, myself and God. The conversations between my mother and I became fraught with anger and bitterness and my trust had left, it would seem, forever.

I took to reading the new Testament over and over again and decided that Jesus was a good man but that I did not

believe any of this religious stuff. Nonetheless, I repeatedly came first in Religious Studies but felt it necessary to add a comment at the end of the GCE exam paper saying "I don't really believe any of this."

It was during this time that I went to confession to one of the college priests. I had no respect for the sacrament and in fact, was not taking it at all seriously, even treating it with disregard. But somehow, something got through the false mask I had got into the habit of wearing. I blurted out, "Everyone lies. I HATE lies! One day I will come face to face with the truth." Little did I realise what I was saying.

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Chapter 6

St. Edward's College

I studied, ate, and slept at St. Edward's College, going home to Sliema for week-ends every six weeks. After I had found out about my parent's situation, there were even times when I tried to avoid these home visits and attempted to stay at the college. But it was no substitute for real life. Although surrounded by my peers and playing a full part in college life, I was hurting in ways I could not then have understood. Nevertheless, there were some good times and a few good friends many of whom I still meet all these years later. Dad would turn up at the college to watch the sports and the football on a Saturday. He always brought along some goodies and stayed to the very end.

Over the next four or five years my attempts at partying and pulling silly pranks with friends did not fool my spirit. The pain was hiding itself in dark places within me. I remember one particular prank when four of us rode home from Valletta in a 'Karozzin', an open horse-drawn carriage. We made a pact together that we would jump off along the way and the last one on would pay the driver. Of course, when the driver saw one and then another of his passengers

take flight, he whipped the horse into a faster gallop and it was even harder to jump. However, jump I did and made my exit at the top of Bisazza Street, landing right onto a police constable! We did pay the driver. You could say it was the 'long arm of the law' which saved me that time or maybe God's grace that I didn't break my neck!

My time at St. Edward's ended much the same as my other schools did. I was now seventeen and a school monitor. One afternoon I was in the common room and three of us, including the head boy and his younger brother, were fooling around. At one point one of them threw a dart which hit me in the head. I had a feeling that this was not accidental and retaliated by punching the culprit rather strongly.

At once, he went to the headmaster who promptly asked me to apologise. "No way!" I said, "He caused the problem, not I"

The sheer injustice of this was more than I could stomach. I packed my things and the next day, I walked out of the school, never to return.

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Chapter 7

Turner Village

What to do next? I certainly did not intend hanging around at home, and, for that matter, in Malta. Most of my close relatives were in the army and the idea of joining the services had often entered my mind as quite honestly, I had no particular sense of vocation. It was just a matter of doing what everyone else I knew did.

The family probably heaved a secret sigh of relief and gave me whatever assistance I needed. Somehow I found myself being sent to Warminster for a Royal Commission Selection Board to be chosen for Cadet training at Sandhurst Royal Military Academy. This didn't go too well as I had no idea which regiment I wanted to join or why. It was obvious to them that I was still unsure as to why I was even there or whether I was serious about joining the army.

During my trip to the U.K to attend this interview, it had been arranged for me to spend a week or two of voluntary work at a care centre for the handicapped called 'Turner Village'. My work was simple. It was in the theatre,

where residents watch films and concerts. My job was polishing the brass and keeping the floors clean. After the failed interview at Warminster, I decided to go back there and asked Dr. Benjacar, who was in charge of Turner Village, if I could return for some time while I worked out what I wanted to do with my life.

For the next two or three months I helped out at the centre and it proved to be an eye-opener for me in many ways.

I must have had long buried memories of the chaos of the war days but I never had a clear view of that other side of life which included the human condition in its broken, and seemingly unfixable, state. They were extremely well looked after but I could not help noticing the basic lifestyle of some of these patients compared with the luxury which I knew their families lived in. Quite a few of them were sons of ambassadors and diplomats and brothers of well-known actors and I was all too aware of the contrast. What struck me too was the quiet realisation that these so called 'unfortunates' did however enjoy the little gifts they were occasionally given and appreciated the simple pleasures of life. All these thoughts and impressions were softly laying a new vision of what life was actually about and what lay beneath the veneer of 'normal' society that chose to show only the 'fashionable' face of reality.

I was also beginning to have a different view of people with severe problems. In the theatre, was a little door at the far end which led to the gym. I would often go to the gym to talk with Mr. Kidman who looked after it. As well as the boys from the centre, Mr. Kidman was also in charge of the visiting patients from Rampton, a secure centre for the criminally insane. In their latter years, when they were no

longer a threat to society, these inmates would be sent over to Turner Village.

On one particular day, I came into the gym as usual. This day, I found it empty. As I was about to leave, the door at the other end was pushed open and one of the Rampton patients barged in. I froze on the spot because, to be honest, he terrified the living daylights out of me. I stood still as he started coming towards me, saliva pouring out of his mouth and glaring hard in my direction. To my immense relief, Mr. Kidman, arrived and gently talked to him, telling him who I was and diffusing the tension in the room. The patient's attitude softened immediately and he put out his hand for me to shake. I learned more in that moment about life, myself and others than all the text books in the world could have taught me.

These incidents had a lasting effect on the way I looked at those with obvious and severe social problems and those whose wound was more hidden. I was made painfully aware of this other type of patient when, eating in the staff dining room, I joked with our waiter, an elegant and handsome young man. I was totally taken aback to see him turn away and start crying. What had I done? Could I put it right? Later, I learned that he was one of the patients. Once I had learned this, I managed to correct things and we got on well after that. To someone like me, who felt he had the right to say whatever he wanted, whenever he wanted, it was a sobering experience and made me take more responsibility for my words.

Eventually, after about two or three months, I did make up my mind and decided I wanted to join the Royal Malta Artillery. That, I thought, was where I belonged. I packed my bags and returned to Malta.

After joining the Army in Malta, I was chosen for

officer training. Malta, being then a British colony, two cadets were chosen each year to go for this training in the U.K. and, ironically, I ended up being chosen and sent for Officer Cadet Training to Sandhurst Royal Military Academy and I was off to the U.K. Again.

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Chapter 8

Army Life

I was standing in line in my new officer cadet uniform on the parade ground, looking to the front as we waited for our first inspection by our Regimental Sergeant Major. Sergeant Major Lord had a formidable reputation. A distinguished war veteran who had been offered several high positions but had decided to remain in the ranks. His booming voice and direct no-nonsense way was also legendary but his particular talent was his uncanny understanding of each cadet.

As we stood there, on our very first day, he moved ever closer, addressing each cadet by name which he had taken the time to learn and memorise before even meeting us. He came and stood in front of me, looked me square in the face and said, "I like you Officer Cadet West. You will do very well in life but this is not the right place for you," and moved on.

I listened to his words and, in the silence of my heart, I knew he was right but I was still very puzzled by this statement.

I entered into the life and training at Sandhurst with

full vigour. There were some aspects which flattered my already growing ego and, although I seemed to possess a natural confidence which made me bold and forthright in most situations, the discipline and grooming of the academy shaped and polished a somewhat reckless young man and I developed skills which, unbeknown to me, would be invaluable in later life.

I loved the uniforms, the stylish rituals and traditions and I relished the sense of honour and achievement that the training pointed us towards. I sat for French lessons alongside Prince Leka of Albania, one of whose cousins, Antoine Apponyi, later became one of my London friends. I met Cadet Festing, the brother of the Grand Master of the Knights of Malta. Although this may sound like some interesting name-dropping, it is important to understand what was happening in my mind and spirit. As well as princes and sons of foreign rulers who attended the military academy, there were also men of extraordinary courage and character. One was Robert Gainher, or Bobby as he was known, who won the sword of Honour and Brian Terry who later joined Intelligence as he lost a kidney from a bad fall while doing steeplechase at Sandhurst.

These two touched my life for the better and Brian especially in an unexpected way. It was forbidden to talk about religion or politics whilst at Sandhurst. It also followed then that it was not looked kindly upon to encourage another to change their religion. This became a rather important ethical question for me when my friend, Brian, who was not a Catholic, persisted in asking me to take him to the Catholic Chapel. It must be said, I took the risk and gave in for one good reason. Somewhere I had heard that if you are responsible for bringing a person into the church, when you die, you will automatically go to

heaven. Now, I had probably got that a little wrong but it did occur to me that it was a pretty good deal and I could sort of put all that out of my mind after that; a sort of 'Holy insurance'.

I went together with him to the Chapel and I sat patiently watching this serious young man whilst he knelt and prayed. I was greatly impressed by this, especially as I had also heard how he visited and helped people with disabilities. This good example was a lovely gift from the Lord and he remained a good friend, visiting me in London several years later.

I stayed on as a Cadet for the better part of fifteen months but RSM Lord had hit the nail on the head and Major General Urquart very kindly said that he had admired my fighting spirit in the boxing ring and couldn't understand what went wrong. I did, or at least I could put my finger on some reasons, or perhaps signposts showing me I was not, as RSM Lord had observed, cut out for that type of battle field.

Overall, I had great admiration for most of what went on at Sandhurst and the tremendous fighting spirit of some of my fellow cadets who, in later years, went on to do great work both in the battlefield and in their communities at home. However, there was another side of the picture that disturbed me.

A particular incident during band night, a regimental ceremonial dinner, gave me a glimpse into this darker side. Band night was a show piece of Sandhurst, a time to inspire new recruits and for the Academy to celebrate its status. It was one of the times, for instance, that we all wore our dress uniform or 'Blues' as they were called. Both officers and cadets sat down together for dinner at this event, joined also by many other eminent guests; foreign royalty, dukes,

famous generals etc. When one of my fellow cadets saw me waving to Peter DeBono, the brother of the 'lateral thinker', Edward DeBono, he was surprised to find out that I had been brought up in Malta. The officer who was sitting beside me joined in the conversation saying that I was really an Englishman living in a 'Wog' country. It cut me to the quick and unearthed the painful memories of witnessing so much snobbery and discrimination which I hated in Malta. It did not do my career any good when I put down my cutlery and turned to give him a very cutting reply saying, "It is men like you, Sir, that make the British hated in some parts of the world."

It was not long after that, that I was called into the General's office and it was decided that I should not continue my army training. I was not at all surprised.

My rebellious spirit emerged for a quick wave on the way back to Malta. I stayed for a short time in Arsenal Barracks and, when told to clean out the toilets, I refused and was put in the guard house. Fortunately I was saved by an officer who knew my family and I was sent to London to wait for a plane to return home.

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Chapter 9

A Respectable Career

Back in Malta, things were not so great. I could feel the disappointment of my family members, particularly my mother and aunts but, as far as I can remember, not from my dad. Personally, I just ignored it and got on with deciding what to do next. With no income, trade or profession or visible means of support, at age 20, this was not an ideal situation. Another family pow-wow got under way and the result was that I was encouraged to go into the other family profession; accountancy. Several members of my family were in accountancy the most notable being my grandfather, Joe Gat Rutter, who was one of the Government's auditors. My mother was also an accomplished bookkeeper and looked after the accounts of the Phoenicia Laundry for many years. So, with no further ado, and since I did not see any other course of action which would get me out of Malta again, I was packed off to the U.K. to become articled to, Oldham Holland & Company, a firm of Chartered Accountants in the City of London. In those days, it was counted as training and no salary whatever was paid to the apprentice. Not only that, Foulkes

Lynch, which provided the tutoring, was due a course fee. All these fees and my living expenses were met by my family in Malta while I settled down to work and study in the big city. After a while, articled clerks like myself, were paid a pittance.

I shared a room and board in a house, just off the High Street Kensington, with my cousin Peter Apap Bologna, who was also studying to qualify as a Chartered Accountant. Like most students, there was another side to this life of work and, supposedly, study. Friends from Sandhurst and Malta started visiting me in Kensington. Peter's cousin, Mabel Strickland, would occasionally phone and our landlady would yell out "There is a gentleman on the line for you!" We would smile, knowing it was probably Peter's aunt Mabel, whose voice was so deep and powerful that many mistook her for a man.

Mabel, the daughter of Lord Strickland, was herself a skilled politician and not a person one could easily say no to. So, when she sent her chauffeur, Mario, to collect us in her Rolls to take us to the theatre, or the ballet or whatever else, we certainly did not refuse. Then there was the time she asked us to take a huge bag of oranges on the plane back from Malta to London and to give them to Rab Butler in the House of Commons. We did so, though with some embarrassment. After a while, she delegated the task of looking after our social well-being to Charles Murland, who wrote some of her speeches. Charles, it turned out, was rather an interesting character of his time. An influential banker and Treasurer of the Royal Ballet School who was also on the board of the Festival Ballet, his friendship and close ties with Rudolf Nureyev are well documented and he is generally portrayed as being a protective doting patron. He was in his middle age and to me he was simply a kind man, full

of charm. This introduction proved to be a fortunate, or depending on how you may look at it, an unfortunate, entry into a whole other way of life.

His world was another universe. I was often asked to the Wigmore Hall to see plays where we were joined by Peggy Ashcroft and many other celebrities. Then to the ballet with Svetlana Beriosova, our seats picked by Michael Wood, a director of Covent Garden. We were always accompanied by very important members of the Royal Ballet. This would be followed by dinner at Mossop Street with many more famous people including, Rita, Nuber Gulbenkian's sister. The fact that I never entered any deeper into Charles' private cliques and inner circles, is only now showing me how, even when I was not aware of it, God's grace was working somewhere inside me.

In those early days Charles Murland kept his homosexuality a secret from his City colleagues and, no doubt, Mabel Strickland. It did not take me long however to realise the true facts and towards the end of my time in accountancy, I slowly moved away from his influence and remained friends at a safe distance. Meanwhile, while all this was going on, accountancy was fading into oblivion and seemed like a ball and chain that I was being forced to drag along.

Needless to say, there was not a lot of studying going on and Peter, who needed some peace and quiet went off to live on his own. Cecil, another friend, who was also living in the same place, also decided to move into his own flat and I moved into a room on my own in Elvaston Place. At last I also had some peace and quiet. At least for one or two days before the visitors and partying started all over again.

Towards the end of my days in accountancy, I became friendly with Jean Leyris. Jean and I got on well together

right from the moment we met. His flat, under artist Annigoni's flat, in Edward's square, just off the High Street Kensington was where I met another new circle of friends, playing cards and going out partying with them. His aunt Jeannie Courtauld, lived in 'Cook's House' in Pullborough; a rather grand house set in some lovely grounds. I went there with Jean and sat down to eat with them in her beautiful dining room. I looked slowly around at the paintings hanging there, impressed by their quality - most of them by well known impressionists. We were just the three of us, and we chatted together as we ate. The conversation came round to Jean. "I could do so much more for Jean," she was saying, "as I pay 19/6d in the pound in tax but he is such a spendthrift, I would only do him more harm than good."

I could not resist myself, I half jokingly said "You could pass it onto me Miss Courtaulds." Her reply was unexpected and has always stayed with me. "David," she said, "if you ever chose to, you could make all the money you want."

I was sent out to work on the accounts of clients all over England and, as far as it went, I did a good and thorough job. I played my part in the various team jobs that were assigned to me and no-one complained about my work. Trouble was, I was bored stiff and life at work was one long dull, grey and monotonous session. For the next two and a half years, I soldiered on, flying back and forth to Malta fairly often, returning to London to dig in my heels and handle the boredom of the day and then living an empty frivolous life with my friends at night. Something had to give, and it did. Although I was successfully completing the every day accountancy work, I was not completing the necessary course work. Without such completed papers, there was no way I was going to receive the final qualification. My attitude did not help much either. It soon became

obvious to them that I was not happy in the profession and I was not trying to hide the fact that I regarded it as a dead-end job. Truth was, I regarded the whole of my life in the same way and, although I seemed to be living the high life, I just did not care about anything anymore.

My Mother came over to London to check out the situation and had a meeting with the accountancy firm. "You're wasting your money and our time," they told her and advised her to withdraw me from the firm.

I was only too pleased to leave and returned back to Malta once again.

I busied myself by taking various jobs and tried to take no notice of the growing concern of my family members. I had no intention of staying very long in Malta, especially being based at home, and had set my sights on returning to London as soon as I had figured out what to do there.

If there was any faith flickering beneath my fake 'devil may care' attitude, it was so feeble and inconsequential, that it failed to break through. I melted into the local social scene, going out with my friends, meeting in their homes for drink parties, cards or just to chat. To everyone who knew me, I was the typical 'man about town'.

Life was about to change. I was about to raise my clenched fist to the God I never really knew. I was about to challenge him with a cry from a place inside me, a forgotten place that I had tried my hardest to ignore.

* * *

Chapter 10

The Turning Point

The swinging 60's suddenly stopped swinging as I gazed down at my mother's body, lying there on the couch where I had placed her. My heart and mind had shouted my challenge to the Almighty but I quietly stepped back and let the carers take over. My father, meanwhile, returned home from work to find this awful emergency and accompanied my mother as she was taken to the Blue Sisters' hospital in Sliema. At the hospital I and all the family waited, and waited, and waited but the doctors could not assure us that she was even going to survive. Weeks went by and slowly, slowly, the doctors gave us more hope.

My father spent most of his free time by her bedside at the hospital and I entered the strange 'limbo' of an arrested life. I had no wish to leave Malta with things in such a 'suspended' state. I needed time to think, adjust; to figure out where I stood. That shout at God was more than words, somewhere in my spirit, I knew it was a 'pact' that I dare not ignore or take lightly.

I waited in Malta for about seven or eight months till my mother had left the hospital and was safe at home. She had fully recovered her general health but her movement down one side was severely restricted. She and dad were now much closer and they spent most of their time together. I remember her following one of the church processions, walking with the aid of a stick behind the statue and saying the rosary with the others. I watched, noted and stayed very quiet. I did not join her but I did know that God had answered my prayer. I also knew that I had no idea how 'to believe in Him' even though I had promised to do just that. For now, I left it somewhere at the back of my mind and got back to living my life with a little less regret.

In late summer 1962, with things at home beginning to settle down, I returned to London and immediately enrolled in an Advertising course at the British Tutorial Institute.

I was living in Kensington Court, and happy to be studying for something new. I applied for a post in an advertising agency in Berger House, Berkley Square. J.Walter Thompson was regarded as one of the top agencies worldwide. I always went for 'the biggest and the best'. When I was about to go for the interview, my friend Roland Flamini turned up and was impressed by the fact that I was attempting to plunge in at the deep end in my new choice of career. "I think I'll come with you," he said confidently. "You don't know how to sell yourself." Roland was a writer and journalist and was far more experienced in these matters than I. However, I was in two minds about this. I thought, "this could make me look stupid". He came along anyway and spent the first ten minutes singing my praises to the interviewer, Valerie Kennedy Browne, and then scooted off and left me to it. Something worked, I secured the job

and started immediately in the TV time buying department working for Peter Rennie.

The 60's were about to start swinging again but the seed of faith had indeed germinated and began to start a 'swing' of its own.

* * *

Chapter 11

J Walter Thompson

Now that I was back in London, life was beginning to hold more promise and I moved to a flat near Cromwell Road where I would often bump into some old friends from Malta. Deirdre Hamilton Hill was one such friend. I often visited her and her husband, Corin Redgrave, in their apartment nearby and I remained friends with both of them for many years.

At work, I was getting to grips with this new and exciting career. For a short time after my arrival, I shared an office with Chris Long. We became friends and have remained so to this day.

Life in any advertising agency is never quiet but in JWT, it was life on overdrive, always fast-paced and hectic. There was no such thing as failure! On one occasion, a decision was made not to promote a particular U.S. product. They decided, at the last minute, that the market in Britain was not quite ready for it. A full campaign was about to start and slots had been booked for it on all the major TV stations. To cancel the advertising at this late hour meant

losing millions of pounds. To replace them with other products at such short notice was going to be very tricky. both the senior managers were abroad at the same time and this was well within the eight week cancellation period and for prime time television. I got to work, and, with the help of four or five secretaries and all my contacts in the various TV companies, I managed it.

As can be expected at this time, I was drinking heavily as this non-ending round of entertaining clients and networking regularly with all the television contacts carried on after hours and well into the night.

If we were not meeting our contacts my colleagues and I used to meet every single day, talk business, drink and then go and relax at some private party.

Had God gone away? Had he entered my thoughts during this time? Vaguely I think, but I did not have any sense of deep religious belief (please explain further) If I had any thought at all about my promise to the Good Lord it was perhaps brought back to me by the visit of my Mother to London. It was now a year and ten months after that awful day of her stroke. She came to visit a specialist, unaccompanied by any nurse or helper. Her courage was amazing, her left leg was still limp and had to be dragged as she walked but she would hobble along with the aid of her walking stick, laughing and joking if, by chance, she stumbled. Her friends in Malta had recommended she visit Mr.Evans, a Harley street specialist, since he had a very good reputation and they felt sure he could help.

When she arrived in London, I went to see her at her hotel room and then accompanied her to Harley Street. At the clinic, I saw her safely into the doctor's room and then turned to leave. But Mr. Evans had other ideas. He stopped

me in my tracks and demanded I stay in the room as he examined her. I was astonished. Imagine the scene, my mother waiting and me being confronted by this strange doctor. I adamantly refused. But he was not going to give in. He looked straight at me and ordered me to stay.

"How old are you?" he asked. I did not answer but he carried on anyway. "Tell me," he went on, "why are you not married?"

"Mind your own business," I quipped back at him. His reply was unexpected. "You are leading a promiscuous life young man. Change your ways!" It would be an understatement to say that I was astonished and yet I remained quiet because I genuinely felt that this was a paternal person, that this was a person who cared. The examination carried on. When it was over he gave us the address of another specialist in Marleybone street and asked me to take my mother there immediately. He told us that the second doctor would examine her and give her the final diagnosis. So off we went with me trailing along, slightly at a loss.

The second doctor was decidedly more abrupt and asked me to tell my mother that if her left side was still paralysed after 22 months, there was no hope of recovery. No way was I going to tell my mother that! I told him so and said that he as a doctor should tell her this himself. He did and my mother replied, through gritted teeth, "we shall see!

The doctor could see that she was a true fighter. My mother's determination had impressed him. As though inspired, he suddenly suggested she should see a physiotherapist in the London Clinic. Too late or not, he arranged for a therapy session there. Off we went, back to the hotel and my mother seemed really happy. "Why?" I asked her, "Why does suggesting a million to one solution mean so much to you?" She then told me the following story:

Sometime after her stroke. Her friend and neighbour who lived opposite us in Victoria Avenue, took a picture of my mother and went to see a Holy man called Frenċ, who lived in Gozo. Frenċ was known all over the islands. It was believed he had visions of our Lady and many people were healed after he had prayed for the intercession of the Mother of God. Frenċ looked at the photo, said he knew the person in question and suggested she needed physiotherapy. He also said that her healing would come about but someone in the family would suffer greatly. I listened quietly but began to understand that this simple Gozitan villager, who knew nothing about my mother, let alone her state of health, was probably speaking on behalf of a higher power. My mind, still wrapped up in my busy life, still failed to see that this had anything to do with my desperate prayer. God was at work, keeping His side of the bargain but was I?

A few days later I once again accompanied her as she went to see the physiotherapist at the London Clinic.

At her very first session the doctor was amazed to see her responding to treatment. Once she had learnt what she had to do, she returned home and carried on with the therapy in Malta. I regularly received news of her progress which told me that she was improving in leaps and bounds. She could now move about with relative ease. I was told she even joined a group who carried a statue of our Lady to various homes and prayed with them. More than this, I learnt that my parents were spending most of their time together and were once again truly united. My father had never lost his love for my mother.

You can imagine my reaction to all of this. There was now a growing belief that, however tragic, circumstances proved God was always there putting things right. Some-

where inside of me I was beginning to know God really was a saviour. However, I was not ready to change anything in my life. Things went back to 'normal' and I continued on my way, mixing with people who I was very fond of but who never talked about faith or God. I went back to the drinking, networking meetings and the late night parties were again in full swing. It was after one of these parties that God's next reminder was delivered. This time it was from a long-time acquaintance who had been taught at the Benedictine college of Ampleforth. I was escorting my date back to her home at two in the morning. As we entered the door of her flat in Knightsbridge, there was Henry, her brother standing in the middle of the room. His look said it all and I withered a little at his angry stare. He did not let either of us say a word but launched into a vicious tirade, tearing me to shreds with every other word. I had heard about Henry, I knew about the tragic car accident he had been involved in, how someone had been killed and how the trauma had effected him for years. I had heard that, after the accident, he had been gripped by a religious fervour and made a habit of pointing out one's faults without hesitation. H accused me of being immoral or amoral and showed his disgust at his sister being out with anyone so morally filthy and debauched. I listened in awe to the long litany of failings he placed at my feet but instead of feeling hurt or upset, I had a mysterious sense of being cleansed.

"Aren't you going to say anything?" his sister asked me, totally bemused by my silence.

"No," I said, smiling "he is just telling the truth."

Henry responded by picking up a book and throwing it at me. "Read this," he said. I caught it and looked at the title; 'Theresa of Avila'. I left the apartment without another word and took the book with me.

Back at work in JWT, things were beginning to sour. My friend Chris Long decided to leave and went to work with Robert Stigwood. At first I carried on but it was not the same and, quite honestly, not as much fun. Henry's words were put on top of the ever mounting pile of 'reminders' that the Lord was now sending. I believe, despite her shortcomings, my mother's prayers and those of her sister Connie, were being heard. One of my contacts in Tyne tees television was a jewess, called Maria Eckhart. She was one of my work contacts who tried to understand why I was becoming so fed up with life. She could see I was heading for self-destruction and tried to encourage me to stop and look at myself. We started going out together and she continued gently trying to talk some sense into me. For once I began to listen. Perhaps it got past my defences because it was coming to me from within that 'other' world I had so completely thrown myself into.

I decided to put my old friend Jean Leyris, forward for a job at JWT and, on my recommendation, they accepted him and he started soon after. Jean is a truly colourful character, intelligent, artistic, outgoing and has turned out as a very successful person. However, not at this job, he soon left and, once again, I felt lost in a sea of madness.

I eventually decided to read the book Henry had thrown at me and that too finally got through. I put it down and realised I had to do something about my life. Going for a walk near the office in Berkley Square, I discovered a church in Farm Street, an old Gothic style church which I entered and found that the confessional was open and a priest was waiting inside. I had no hesitation and went straight in and started unloading my soul's saga onto the listening priest. When I had at last finished there was

silence. I waited, "Have you murdered anyone?" asked the priest. "No," I replied.

"Ah well, at least there is some good in you!" and laughed.

I heaved a sigh of relief - that was the beginning.

* * *

Chapter 12

The Grand Tour

St. Paul had an amazing experience on the road to Damascus. He was literally knocked off his high horse and turned around in mind, body and spirit within a few glorious minutes. However, in his letter to the Christians in Rome, he openly says,

"For I do not understand my own actions. For I do not do what I want, but I do the very thing I hate." Romans 7:15

In my case, the horse was missing, the bright light was missing, the speed was missing but the hand of the Lord was surely there. My mind and spirit knew he had answered my call and I felt the need to keep my promise to Him. Like Paul, however, I found that the 'Old Man' was still very much around.

Back at work, I found nothing really excited me, in fact it was beginning to depress me. Now that Jean had decided to move on, I decided that it was also time for me to do the same.

I left the advertising world behind and never looked back. Enough was enough! I took some temporary assignments in my fall-back career of accountancy to keep me

going but I met up with Jean and he came up with a much more interesting suggestion.

"Why don't we take off and drive round Europe?" he suggested. Seemed like a pretty good idea to me, better than hanging around in London just then.

It was now early in 1963 and we set off in his Riley, going down south to Dover and taking the ferry to northern France and then on to Meudon, near Paris where Jean's parents lived. Now this seemed like a great way to escape. We hung around there for about a month before setting off again through Switzerland on our way to Italy.

It was all easy going till we hit the mountains. We climbed higher and higher, the road winding around one curve after another. It was all plain sailing, no problems at all until we turned one particular curve and on into a long straight section. Jean went silent for a while and the car seemed to be losing speed. "What's happening", he said "we seem to be slipping" It was only then that we saw were surrounded by a thin layer of snow and ice. I could also see, on Jean's side there was a massive drop. We slowed to a painful crawl as the wheels began sliding even more. "Get out and push!" yelled Jean, hands gripping the wheel as the car came to a halt. One back wheel was spinning in mid air over the edge."What!" I objected, "If I do that your side will be heavier. It will go over for sure."

"Just get out and push," he shouted.

I did so, and together we manoeuvred the car back onto to road. That moment still sticks in my mind. The rest of the journey seemed like a picnic after that and we drove on towards Milan.

As soon as we arrived in Milan, we parked the car and went to see Anna Capprici, a friend who had been my neighbour in Kensington Court in London. We locked the

car and left it outside, our best suits hanging from the hooks inside the back window, other belongings strewed over the back seat. We returned to find all of it gone. We were left penniless, except for what we had in our pockets. Nevertheless, we carried on and found a place to stay in Via Bronzino, not far from the La Scala opera house. After a couple of weeks we headed off again, this time towards Rome.

We had realised by this time, that we would have to find some work to keep us going, at least till things got sorted out. Nothing very grand, something easy and simple, so we tried our hand as waiters in a restaurant just outside the Vatican city. I lasted for a few days and was thrown out because I was useless at it while Jean just took it in his stride and swanned his way through it with relative ease.

During all of this, we were living in the centre of Rome in via Buenos Aries and our social life was beginning to look up. Jean was like a magnet and we seemed to be getting invited to one party after another. We mixed easily with the local crowd of up-coming young artists and go-getters and savoured all the interest and life of Rome. Often, we would bump into old friends from London. Roland Flamini, who had introduced me to J.Walter Thompson, showed up a few times as he was then sharing a flat with the actor, Anthony Steel.

After about six weeks of this, a chance meeting with the film director, Fellini changed things totally. He asked us to go and see Maria Cellis, the wardrobe mistress for the film 'Cleopatra'. A day or two later we went up to Cinecitta and, after a few enquiries, found ourselves in a wide hallway waiting in a long queue of about a hundred people. I looked around at the muscley males around us and imagined them in gladiatorial costume. In contrast, Jean and I looked like

typical, well dressed English gentlemen, totally out of place. I said, "Jean, I am not standing around here for ever." and charged off, going straight up to the woman holding a clipboard at the head of the queue. She looked up as I approached. "Are you Maria Cellis?" I asked. "Yes, she said. I told her that Fellini had sent us. "Yes, I know she replied and told us we were to be assigned as Roman senators. Jean was getting right into it and was eager to start. Once again, I was getting tugged the other way. I loved films, the theatre but as a viewer, not as an actor. I felt repulsed with what I saw. It was as though something bigger than me was directing me all my life. I knew this was just not for me. The very next night, on my birthday, I was on a plane bound for Malta. Jean stayed on eventually becoming a producer and director of several successful films and stage events. He is now a well known French sculptor and artist.

Once again, I was back in Malta, totally broke, even my cheque for the flight had bounced and my family had to step in and pay for it.

This time, however, I didn't hang around for very long, I was off again almost immediately and headed back to London to get my life back on track.

* * *

Chapter 13

Time of Trial

The seed of faith which had been planted after my mother's recovery had begun to sprout. It had lain dormant, indeed a little suppressed, during my European jaunt. To some extent, I had used the trip as a convenient distraction, steering away from religious or spiritual thoughts or conversations. But it had not worked. Instead it had only heightened the absurdity of this empty way of life and now it was beginning to seriously depress me. I now had to admit to myself that there was more to existence than this and I was simply wasting my time. This was one of the reasons I had hurried back to London. That small glimpse of peace I had experienced in the church in Farm Street pointed the way forward. I started going to Mass and confession on a regular basis and since I was living just off the High Street Kensington I found myself gravitating towards the Brompton Oratory which became my solid base.

Some time in these early months my friend, Chris Long, turned up and we renewed our friendship. He stayed with me for a week or two and then moved on. I enjoyed his

company, it was easy and non demanding and I began occasionally mixing with his current crowd. Johnny Layton who is famous for his hit song, "Johnny Remember Me" came along with Chris to my 25th birthday. He and Mike Sarne were old school friends of Chris. This time, however, I stayed true to my intention to go deeper, not just to 'go with the flow'. I was finding it difficult but I knew the alternative was never really living.

I enjoyed the company of the new circle of friends I was now mixing with. Most of these I met through Sally Alexander who later married John Thaw. Nearly all of them were in the arts and media; Ian McShane, John Hurt, Nicol Williamson and others, all of whom were just out of acting school and starting out on their careers. I also stayed in touch with Corin and Deirdre who I visited from time to time. They all accepted that I was the 'religious' one, since I now talked freely about my ideas. At one time, Corin, who was preparing for a part in a new film, asked me to show him how monks sat, how they moved.

We often all met together in Sally's house and on one of these occasions I found myself sitting next to someone who became very important to me. Jackie and I hit it off immediately and soon we were together most of the time. For the next eight months to a year, we were always together and I felt very comfortable with her. She seemed to belong in my life, as though a part of my family. In fact she reminded me of my father in the way she coped with every-day life. Even though half of Knightsbridge would stop to stare at her, she never took much notice of it. I met her parents and, and although my mother never met Jackie, she sent her an 'Our Lady of Sorrows' medallion which Jackie wore around her neck.

However, all this time the inner search still continued

and even intensified. I had spent months reading the saints, the philosophers especially Plato's republic, and I knew there was something specific I should be doing with my life. Although I had a deep feeling of what it may be I wanted to have some degree of certainty.

One day I was sitting on the bed, reading, when I looked up and saw an image on my ceiling. I could see the impression of a man kneeling on one of those wooden kneelers found in a church. I was intrigued, this was nothing like the images one might see on a ceiling which changes as one picks out different cracks and discolouration in the stones. This was different. It stayed there like a ray of sunshine.

I immediately tested it by pulling the curtains, putting on and off the lights. Still it stayed. I finally accepted that it was there and was not a figment of my imagination, nor a ray of sunshine.

I looked at it and thought, "So what".

A voice deep within me said, "Pray, always pray".

Without any doubt, I knew at that moment, and still do today, what I was being called to do. It immediately filled an empty void within me and will always continue to do so. I cannot tell you, how grateful to God I was for those words.

I was more than grateful to God for the interest I felt He was showing me, providing me with one of the most beautiful girls I had ever seen. I appreciated this but it was her personality and shyness which I found more attractive. Meeting all these amazing people, at Sally's house was really like a treasure being handed out to me and this paradoxical desire for the truth mixed with a great feeling of love for these people, sent my mind into a state of numb confusion. Also, at the time, I was working for the World Council of Churches and living on a pittance.

When Jackie came up to London, I would send her to stay with my friends who lived near Hyde Park. The struggle was immense to keep on the right track.

This pull towards a more committed Christian life now began to pull me apart. My relationship with Jackie was being affected since I knew in my spirit, that it was not meant to continue. I knew it was not what God wanted for either of us. As this was going on Jackie was not aware of what was brewing. When I finally told her, she said that she understood. I am not sure that she did. This was one of the most painful and difficult events in my life. More painful was the fact that I still loved her but the final decision was made after I had an explicit dream which confirmed that I was meant to move away. The Lord, once again, was involving Himself in my life but I was totally heartbroken.

To anyone who has felt the need to break off a relationship with someone they are still in love with, there is no need to spell out how this affected me. To someone who hasn't been through that, words just do not do it justice!

As I sat alone in my room, I knew I could not stay. Almost immediately, I used whatever money I had managed to save and left, taking a flight back to Malta to escape the painful situation

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Chapter 14

Isolation in Malta

This time, back in Malta, I was not going to join the party set or waste my time going back on my new commitment to 'find the truth'. This time, I was in hell!

I tackled everything I did with dogged determination and a certain amount of stoicism but there was a raging storm going on inside and I was barely managing to keep the boat steady. I went back to my avid reading of Augustine and the lives of the saints together with excursions into the bible. Henry, my friend who 'threw the book at me' in London, was now back in Malta and we would endlessly discuss our faith, say the rosary together and go to mass. Henry loved God with a passion but he was a flawed genius. He painted, played the piano magnificently, sang beautifully and spoke many languages including Greek and Latin. However, he was highly erratic and his eccentric behaviour sometimes drove me crazy and worried both my mum and dad. He would sell me one of his paintings and a few days later, when I was out, would come in through a window and

take it back. Nonetheless, he was a good friend and I appreciated him in many ways.

I took on some small jobs but was spending most of my time at home, keeping clear of all the old haunts of the past and did not mix with the party crowd at all. However, some of my friends would make a point of dropping in regularly to see me and I would play 'canasta' at home with mum, Cecil and Roger. My mother would ask me what had happened to change me so much but I would not answer. It was too difficult to explain it to her.

I felt the need to expand my boundaries and started a correspondence course in scriptwriting run by Scriptwriters TV in 35 Fleet Street, London.

And so it continued for the next year or so, reading, writing, praying and discussing whilst my mind was still in a terrible state. I would continue to turn down all invitations, even those from my friends in London. Sally invited me to her wedding with John Thaw but I declined and sent them a present to wish them well. Then, when I sent some of my writing samples to the scriptwriters' in Fleet Street, someone there wanted to come out to Malta to discuss my work. I said, "no, I am not interested. Don't bother coming."

His reply was, "no man is an island", and I stopped my correspondence with him.

One good aspect of this time was to see my mother and father going out for drinks together and at least things seemed more normal at home.

* * *

My new found faith had told me what to believe in but not how to go about it. I was like a lost traveller in a strange city. I continued to pour through the unfamiliar pages of the Old

Testament, read the New Testament and plough heavily through the works of St. Augustine. Rather arrogantly I identified with Augustine and felt at one with his long desperate struggle to embrace the Truth.

My mother had told me a lovely story about my little niece who it seems had a great love of St. Martin de Porres as indeed my mother did. It seems my niece would often wander away from mummy and have quiet chats with the statues ending with "Sweet Saint Martin De Porres, how I love you."

I knew very well what I had to do to be a decent Christian but the how perplexed me. The thought of twenty four hours battling with my negative, destructive thoughts haunted me and life seemed to have lost its joy and was nothing but an endless battle.

One day I was sitting at a desk in my shorts and bare footed - everything had become such an effort. The 'Life of Augustine' was lying on the table and I was staring vacantly nowhere.

My little niece entered and blabbered on about everything and nothing. My heart was filled with a sadness and I prayed in the silence of my heart "Sweet Lord, this little girl is so good and innocent. Please help me to be like her. Show me what it is in her that makes her so good."

As if she had heard my unspoken words, this little girl turned round and said to me, "Don't try to understand me Uncle David, you never will."

I was amazed and startled, the words resounded in the very depth of my being. They were spoken with an authority beyond her years. I rushed up to tell her mother what had just happened and as though to put all in perspective, this little girl, who never showed any familiarity, slapped my behind!

From then on I realised that motives were often unfathomable and man was wrapped in the very mystery of God Himself. From then on I feared anyone who thought he knew everything about me or anyone. I accepted the counsel of very few and relied more and more on the Spirit of God working within me. Later on in life, I learned to listen to only very few people, such as Fr. Michael Hollings whose only advice is well chosen and is always to do with the love of God.

Chapter 15

Return to England 1966

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It was nearly two years since I had left London. Now I was back, my mind still swimming in dark, stormy waters, but firm in my resolution to continue my spiritual quest. My first port of call was the Brompton Oratory where I spoke to one of the priests. This turned out to be the beginning of a very long friendship. Father Damian Wood seemed to understand my situation immediately and took me to a block of apartments in Sumner Place, South Kensington which was run by a wonderfully kind soul called Nellie Buckley. She rented me a bedsit at a good reasonable price. However, for the next six months while I was getting onto my feet, she never actually collected any rent.

These were the leanest times in my life. I had always said to the Lord that I wanted to live like the poor. Well, this was as close as I got. Fr. Damian knew what a struggle I was going through and realised that I was not going to contact

my family for financial help so he stepped in and supported me himself while I looked for a job.

I had prayed, "Lord, I know I will let you down if I am left to myself. Please surround me with saints!" and He did.

I then met Lalage Hall who lived in the rooms opposite my own. One day, I noticed a book about the Stigmatised monk, Padre Pio, lying on the hall table near her door. My grandmother had told me stories about Padre Pio who was reputed to have the stigmata, the wounds of Christ. She had told me that he said his mass at 5 am every morning and that that was the best time to ask him to pray for me. I did so and had developed quite a strong interest in him. I was curious to see this green book with his name on it sitting outside my door. The next time I spoke to Lalage I brought the conversation round to God and to my delight, she responded with great interest and enthusiasm. Her father was a Harley Street Specialist and her mother a London socialite, Viola Banks, who wrote a book called the Dorset Heritage. In it she described Lalage's grandmother, entertaining the king and queen at their home in Dorset. This was the world that Lalage had grown up in, surrounded by wealth and exclusivity. However, her own search for a deeper meaning in life had led her to a simplicity and an honest spirituality which I marvelled at. She was a convert to Catholicism and deeply in love with the Lord. This, I would say, was what struck me most.

Lalage became my spiritual helpmate and sister in Christ and I met with her nearly every evening for prayer, sometimes for the rosary or meditation or both. She too would help me make it through these lean times by leaving the occasional bowl of soup outside my door or a pile of coins in a cup to feed the gas heater.

During that time, the Lord helped me to keep my mind

on the right road by creating all kinds of distractions. Pigeons would fly into my little room during thoughts that caused me unease and the radio would come into full blast without me turning it on.

Joe, on his rounds, collecting thrown out antiques would call me in the middle of the night to join him in his flat and keep me from dwelling on fear and useless thoughts. Janni, an actor of small parts from S.A. would bring me soup in cartons and bring me some of his paintings.

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Chapter 16

So, What was I to do?

So, what was I to do? Was God telling me I should not marry? Was He telling me I should be a monk? Quite honestly, that seemed a bit too far to jump!

I decided what I needed was some peace and quiet to think things over and to meditate. Lalage told me about an Abbey on the Isle of White that accepted visitors such as me. With Lalage's help, I packed my bags and set off immediately.

The place was beautiful and I joined in the austere way of life for a few weeks, waking up at four or five in the morning and joining in prayer. No matter, it did not make much difference to my state of mind, or for that matter, my spirit.

One of the monks there was called Fr. Paul Ziegler. Fr Ziegler was a wise and saintly soul. He was given all the menial jobs and did them joyfully even though he was much respected by all the monks, and was known, both in and outside the monastery, for his brilliance and holiness.

It was he who was asked to counsel me and this saintly

monk did so to the best of his ability. One day he came into my room and we chatted and I expressed all my thoughts and fears, laying them out before him in as full a way as possible. After being silent for weeks, I could see them all clearly.

To this day, I still remember his response. His face was radiant and he looked at me and smiled. "David" he said at last, "you make mountains out of molehills!"

Perhaps grace was working overtime in those moments but these words actually proved helpful and, also by the grace of God, they stuck in my mind, always to be remembered in tough times.

I returned to London a little calmed and tried to settle back down. I couldn't.

I thought I would give the monk idea another chance. Perhaps I was meant to go to a different monastery. I packed my bags again and went off to Aylesford Priory where they were building a new block of toilets for the pilgrims who came to the shrine. I helped out with the building work and kept my head down. After a few days a young man was asked to come and talk to me. He was very young but he spoke with such deep faith that it made me wonder if he was in fact as young as he looked. What came out of his mouth sounded like the words of a wise old man. I was thinking, "what a lot of faith he has," when the words came into my mind, "If you had as much faith as a grain of mustard seed, you could say to this mountain get up and throw yourself into the sea, and it would obey." As I looked up it seemed as though the hill which I saw in the distance began to move towards me. It gave me such a fright that I stopped thinking and listened further to this young man's wisdom.

I never explained my predicament to him but some-

thing happened as I listened to him. I went back to my room in a more reflective mood and soaked it all in.

The following morning, one of the older monks came into my room. He sat down on the bed and we talked together. He sounded very wise and practical so I told him my story. He listened quietly to what I had to say and then he said "Love has no chains David".

I was not sure at the time what he meant by that but, it was as though the world had stopped and I realised that I was not where I should be. That same day, I packed my bags and left, I must say, with some relief.

Chapter 17

Breakthrough

When I was back in London, Father Damian suggested that I join the SVDP (St. Vincent DePaul Society) which met there at the Oratory. I did so and things really started getting interesting. Life took on a whole new colour.

One of the members of this group was John Farah. He was around my age and we immediately became good friends and I would spend a lot of time with his family. John and I would go together, under the SVDP patronage, to St. Botolphs in Bishopsgate where we would help to look after alcoholics and drug addicts or go to visit the sick in the Royal Marsden Hospital. John was a great favourite with many of the patients. I remember one nurse pointing out an old African patient to me. "Do you see that man," she said. "He lives just to see John come to see him on a Saturday. It is the highlight of his week." I believed her as I had seen it for myself. I had watched John during one of these visits. He would listen so intently as the man struggled to talk and his face seemed to change colour as he empathised with his suffering.

These were the 'saints' that the Lord had chosen to surround me with but, as I struggled along, I needed more reassurance that I was still on the right road. I was assigned to go and see some elderly people who lived in the Chelsea Trust Houses. Mrs. McCormack was totally blind and I would bring her a supply of audio tapes to listen to. Another was Mrs Linehan. "Are you hungry?" she would ask as soon as I entered her tiny little apartment. I looked pretty gaunt as I rarely ate so, whether I answered or not, she would insist on giving me a sandwich. I talked to her about Padre Pio and what my grandmother had told me about him, how people wrote to him and were helped. She said "I'd like to write to him."

"Go ahead", I told her.

"Then why did you never write to him?" she asked.

"Because I don't see why he would answer me but he will definitely answer your letter," I replied.

"O.K.", she said, "I will write".

Somehow, I had it in my mind that, if I wrote I would not get a reply but I was sure he would answer this kind woman. At that moment, I had a cunning plan. "Tell him to pray for a friend of yours," I said casually. "But don't mention my name." She agreed happily and the letter was posted.

Some time later, I went to see her again. "I got a reply from Padre Pio," she said. "What did he say?" I asked.

He said, "tell that friend of yours I have been praying for him for a long time!"

* * *

Chapter 18

Revolution Club

It was around 1967 and life was still a strange mix of celebrity friends and church. One typical story of this time stands out in my memory. I was staying for a short while in a house in Kings Road Chelsea belonging to a friend of mine. One day, a South American friend of his, who was a communist and a multi-millionaire, asked me to join him at the Revolution Club off Berkley Square. This was the meeting place of all those in the jet-set. Incidentally, this chap had just ordered a number of cars from the company belonging to the person I was staying with.

When we got to the club, he ordered a bottle of whisky and we sat down to spend a long night, talking and observing all the people around.

Sometime later, a friend of mine called Chris, turned up with Bob Stigwood and a few other people. They all huddled off into a corner and Chris asked us to join them. This we did.

The evening wore on and I sat next to this very well-dressed young man who had a strange accent which I could not place. He seemed to have visited many countries and we

talked pleasantly about his every day experiences in these countries - Germany, America and other places. He was very unassuming, friendly and we enjoyed chatting about everything and nothing.

The following morning, I returned to Battersea where I was staying with another friend called Leonard and his family.

When I woke late that morning, his sister-in-law asked me where I had been gallivanting the night before. I very casually mentioned that I had been to the Revolution Club. She said, "have you read the newspapers this morning?" This was unexpected as I was still half asleep. She said, "it was all over the newspapers that the Beatles were at the Revolution Club."

I was amused and phoned my friend, Chris, to ask if this was true. I jokingly said, "if I had known, I would have asked them for an autograph".

Chris asked me to repeat myself as he was astonished at my reply. I again repeated what I said.

He laughingly replied over the phone, "Westy you're incredible! Only you could sit talking to Paul McCartney for three hours without realising who he was".

* * *

Chapter 19

Flowers

By this time, things were beginning to improve a little financially. One of the members of the SVDP was a man who owned a business and I did some bookkeeping for him for a while but the job did not last long as I was still finding it hard to concentrate. However, I managed to pay off my back-rent and continued to pick up small, low paying jobs as they came along. At least I was now keeping my head above the water.

I had also had some contact with Jackie who was now well launched on an acting career. I was glad we had managed to remain friends and was careful to keep it at that level. It seemed that our friendship may also have been important to the Lord as well. Even in this, he showed His kind touch.

I was walking down Sloane Street one early afternoon and gazed at the flowers displayed elegantly in a florists near Knightsbridge station. A voice within me said, "buy Jackie some flowers." It was quite insistent. I smiled ruefully as I was walking through one of the most expensive areas in

London. Buying flowers here would cost an arm and a leg and I only had a few pennies at most in my pocket. The thought would not go away but I shrugged it off and ambled my way calmly down to Sloane Square. I was out of a job at the time and was trying to keep myself calm, desperately thinking of what sort of work I should be doing.

That evening I went to the Brompton Oratory and called on Damian. As usual, we talked about Christ, art, and everything that came to mind. Slowly my troubles seemed to dissolve and calmness crept back again.

I decided to phone Jackie and asked Damian if I could use his phone to call her from his room. Luckily, she was in and happy to talk.

Half way through our conversation she said, "thank you for the flowers."

"What flowers?" I said, my mind racing back to the afternoon in Sloane Street. I was intrigued, if not a little taken aback. It then dawned on me that perhaps someone else had sent her the flowers so I asked her who she thought she was talking to?

"Don't be so silly! its you, David," she replied.

"Which David," I asked.

"David West, of course."

I thought for a bit and decided to ask about the flowers themselves. "What kind of flowers are they?"

"White ones," she said, now sounding a little annoyed.

"And how do you know they are from me?" I said.

She sighed in exasperation as she told me that they were signed and she assured me she knew my handwriting which was on the card, right there in front of her.

I gave up and accepted the strange fact. All I can say is that the Angels were hard at work and God alone knows

why He did this. Perhaps she needed them at that point. Praise God! Were the white flowers symbolic of the blessings brought about by future prayers? Perhaps.

* * *

Chapter 20

Resurrection

Although the practical side of life was slowly beginning to improve, during this time of soul searching the emotional and mental confusion was at times totally unbearable. A very heavy depression set in which I could in no way shake off. My new found vulnerability gave me a feeling of helplessness and I could see no way of clarifying my thoughts. I was still racked with doubt, turmoil and guilt and the more healthy feelings of love, trust, hope and freedom were missing. I could latch on to nothing, my mind was a maze and I was lost in it.

This struggle, to keep an objective perspective, had been going on now for two to three years and my face was often bathed in a sweat of heavy depression.

At one point, in a moment of fear, I had agreed to see a psychiatrist. Our meeting was brief since his, not so reassuring, advice was that this may go on forever and I just had to keep on doing my best. Curiously enough, instead of dampening me, these words created an anger in me which guaranteed a fight! I was strangely convinced that there was a way out and I intended proving him very wrong.

I desperately tried everything I knew to calm myself and resolve these anxieties. I read the Jesus' words, "Consider the lilies of the field, consider their ways ..." and decided to do just that. I would go into the park and just sit, looking at the flowers, feeling my hands, my body and saying to myself "I am". It was a sort of relaxation exercise which, for a while, kept out all the dubious and negative thoughts which were bombarding my mind.

Gradually my feeling of self worth started returning. On one of these troubled nights I had a dream. In the dream I was walking down a road in pitch darkness when I saw a strange group of people. One man was pushing a wheelbarrow with dead bodies lying inside it in all sorts of contorted shapes. Then the man, pushing the barrow, looked straight into my eyes and took fright. He let go of the barrow and fled instantly followed by all the others who suddenly came to life. I looked at the proceedings, in my dream, in utter amazement.

The next morning I saw Damian and told him about it. He listened and then suggested the dream may be heralding my resurrection and all the dead fleeing were those hurts, pains and anxieties in my life.

As I listened to his explanation, something happened. I knew I would never be depressed again. Sad perhaps, unhappy yes, but that despair and lack of hope, praise God, was gone and never returned.

Now, even during waking hours, the bright glimpses of God's eternal light started to pierce through the darkness.

I was on my way to visit a friend and was walking down The Cromwell Road. Without warning my perception was suddenly drawn into a truly different state. It was the same road, the same London, the same world but I saw it in a totally new light. I realised, or rather knew, that what I saw,

what I didn't see and where I was existing, was united into one. No part of it was excluded for there were no parts. It was all one. This happened in a split second but to this day, the awareness of that moment is as real and vivid as when it happened. The euphoria which followed was exhilarating and I accepted it with a natural grace, the grace of that moment.

Now, deep in my subconscious, things were showing me that inner healing was taking place.

One night I dreamed that I was at the circus. I love the circus. I was watching all the acts, the trapeze, the horses, the acrobats and it felt as though I was really there and accompanied by the unseen Holy Spirit.

Then I noticed four or five jugglers dressed in black who stepped out of the enclosure into the central ring. Somehow I knew they represented all that was cunning and dark yet to look at they were magnificent, composed and very much in control. Their mastery gave the art an apparent ease.

From nowhere came these equally splendid characters dressed in white who unobtrusively took their places behind each of the men dressed in black. They reached out and calmly took over the juggling. It was so effortless, composed and so cleverly done that the men in black realised they were outwitted and eased their way out without so much as a backward glance. I knew at that moment that the good would always triumph over evil, there was no match. The lasting impression of that dream was the utter serenity of this triumph.

As well as struggling with psychological pain and depression, I also had to cope with a physical problem that had dogged me since the age of three. The pains in my left leg which paralysed me as a child in Gozo, had not gone

away completely. For the past seven or eight years, they had returned with a vengeance. My leg would suddenly go dead on me and I would be forced to walk with a painful limp for weeks on end. At times, it would be so agonising, I would have to receive pain killing injections to enable me to go on.

A few weeks after these dreams and experiences, I was once again being treated at hospital for my leg problem. I spoke on the phone to Jaime, a doctor friend of mine, who told me that it was congenital, I had been born with a loose ligament which meant I would just have to live with it.

I had no intention of doing so. "Lord," I said, "that's enough, no more." and indeed it has never returned since that day.

This showed me that, when spiritual healing takes place, other healings often follow.

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Chapter 21

Steps in the right direction

I had embarked on a new chapter in my life and, in all important journeys, one needs a good guide. Lalage asked me to come with her to Oxford to see a priest called Father Michael Hollings who was her confessor. He was an ex-military man, Brigade of Guards who had been highly decorated for his bravery during the war but had eventually become a priest. He had spent some weeks on private retreat with Padre Pio who used to call him 'Il mio Michelino' (my little Michael). Many people from all walks of life, came to see him for counselling. He was totally non-partial. Whether it was a student at the Chapliancy or Mother Theresa, who regularly came to see him when she was in London, they would be treated with equal urgency. Both would be kept waiting if there was someone in more need.

This was a man I could relate to. He became my friend and counsellor for the rest of my life, or at least, till his death in 1997.

As well as the Lord's hand, His servant, Padre Pio's hand was becoming more obvious in my journey. I later

found out that even Mr. Evans, the Harley Street specialist who told me to mend my ways when I visited him with my mother, was connected to Padre Pio. He is mentioned in a book as his favourite English doctor.

It was around this time that Padre Pio stepped into my life, and my dreams, in a more prophetic way. Although I did not know it at the time, this dream pointed to a time which would be important to me in the future.

In my dream, I was standing by the side of a bridge. Across it was a high mountain covered in trees and bushes. I could see a group of monks walking calmly across the bridge they appeared to be in no hurry as they enjoyed the tranquility of their walk.

I watched fascinated as they crossed to my end where there was a gravel road, The monk leading the group came towards me and bent down to pick a little white flower growing on the side near me.

He looked at me intently and gave me the flower then turned and walked on to join the rest down the road.

My understanding was that the littlest things in life are so very precious. I could also sense a concern and love from this unknown monk who lived the gospel. I believe it was Padre Pio at the age of thirty. The significance of the bridge, the hill and the gravel path would only become clear to me many, many years later.

Meanwhile, Father Michael gave me sure and honest direction. He never waffled or wasted words. He was direct and to the point and refreshingly easy to understand.

He was often asked to be a speaker at charity raising

events. On one occasion, Lalage came to me and asked if I minded going to a one of these charity luncheons which was being held at the Guildhall in London. She was unable to be there herself and felt that neither her ticket nor the meal should be wasted. I was in two minds about going since I was acutely aware that I would not be suitably dressed for the occasion. My job at the Army & Navy Department Store Accounts Department barely paid me enough money to survive let alone buy an expensive outfit. Rather reluctantly I went dressed in my one remaining pin stripe suit, while aware that the soles of my shoes were falling to pieces.

As expected, the place was beautifully elegant and everything was set out for a splendid meal to which a hundred or more had been invited. Father Michael Hollings addressed the guests. It seems the meal was organised to raise money for the chaplaincy at Oxford. Father Michael thanked Princess Lee Radziwill and the guests and said, "I have often made appeals for charity, this time I'm not asking for hundreds but thousands" He mentioned the fact that cheques would be welcome. It seems, as one, the guests responded and many signed away varying sums of money.

I felt more than inadequate but calmly savoured every moment of the meal and felt grateful for the enjoyable interlude.

When it was over, Fr. Michael stood at the door thanking everyone for their generosity and I was one of the very last to leave. I instantly blurted out my apologies to Michael as I felt guilty about having had nothing to give.

He smiled, looked at me and as I walked away, said, "Don't worry, one day you will do more for me than anyone here."

In what way, I am supposed to do that, only God knows

but I do hope it was the Lord who said it and I would be only too glad to see it coming about.

* * *

Chapter 22

Mum Dies

I had been back in London for over a year and it was now 1967. I was lying on my bed meditating, when I felt, or rather actually knew, that someone very much wanted to see me. There was a longing involved and I could only think of two people who could possibly want to see me that much. I had a little conversation in my mind in which I said, "Lord, Padre Pio has bilocated and been seen in various places at the same time. I'm no saint, but I'm sure you'll let whoever wants to see me, see me."

A few days later I received a telegram telling me my mother was very ill. I took the first flight out and arrived in Malta to find my mother was in Hospital in a coma. She had had cerebral thromboses and there was little likelihood of her ever recovering.

My heart was saddened especially remembering my parting words that she would never see me again. The memory of those words haunted me even though they were spoken with no malice, just a certainty. My aunt who had played an important role in bringing me to Christ, came up

to me. "David," she said, "there is something I want to tell you."

I listened to her quietly while she told me that a few days before my mother had her stroke, she was lying down having a siesta. My father who now shared the room was with her and both were fully awake.

"George," she said suddenly, "David has come to see me."

She then kept up a conversation for quite sometime. It all sounded very sensible but Dad could neither see nor hear me. When she was finished, it seemed to have calmed her spirit.

I spoke about it to my father a long time afterwards and he assured me that it was all true.

It was only a week or so after that event, that I was now standing by her bedside, unable to communicate with her. It seems, poor mum had wanted to say goodbye too.

As well as calming my mothers's spirit at the time, it also helped me. In later years, whenever I remembered our original sad parting, my aunt's story always gave me great peace. My mum died a few days later and I returned to London immediately after the funeral.

Getting back to London, I resumed my life but I now realised that I could not go on in this rather nomadic existence. I needed to settle down. If I was meant to follow God in the world, I needed to get a better career and possibly think of supporting a family eventually.

* * *

Chapter 23

Denton and Chelsea Bridge

Now back in London, I was still struggling with my new found faith so I asked the Lord to surround me with saintly people to share my thoughts with and to give me strength and encouragement.

Lalage, my good friend, took me to Denton, a tiny little village near Oxford. This was a meeting place for a new type of prayer group. It was held in the garden room of a private house a lovely annex, surrounded by shrubs and flowers. Joan led us in prayer and people of all ages and different denominations, turned up from near and far. This little room of worship often held as many as twenty people, all praising God in tongues, giving witness and testifying to God's grace. They had one common objective which was to bring as many people as possible into His light.

I had spent a few evenings in the company of these Christians and had really come to sense a oneness even though doctrinally there were some points on which we were not all in agreement. However, love, concern and understanding seemed to put this very much into the background and a desire to put Christ before everything else

held us all in a common purpose. Even though many had personal problems and were going through difficult times, an overriding sense of joy in the Risen Christ prevailed as each of us shared in the gifts of the Holy Spirit.

A great sense of Christ's presence quite overwhelmed me yet references to Jacob and Esau had caused a sense of grief. I recognised the commitment of this group and felt acutely the pain of my struggle to stay with Christ. How often had I looked back in the past; fallen back into my old ways. Temptation walked alongside me and my path was never very steady. The hedonistic streak within me made me very conscious of the things I was missing out on, yet Christ seemed to have taken me by the hand. I was always being dragged on. I felt that my will was like a piece of putty and I never knew whether I was responding to my own will or whether Christ had really taken over more than I dreamed possible.

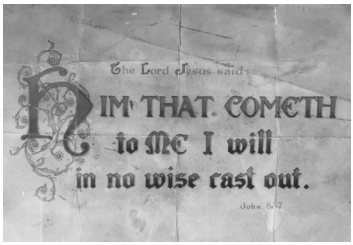
This feeling stayed with me when I reached London where I lived. The next day was a grey humid day. London was deserted as, if I remember rightly, it was around Easter and many had gone away for a few days of celebration - what sort of celebration remains dubious as Christianity seemed to have gone out of the heart of most people in that city.

I walked down South Kensington onto a bridge to Battersea, where I spent time with some dear friends of mine who were amused but not disparaging about my new found beliefs. In fact I shared my experiences with them and they seemed ready to accept most as being authentic.

I left them and was on my way back to my flat, walking across Battersea Bridge. As I crossed the bridge I sensed the deceitfulness of my life and a feeling of sadness enveloped me. But, far from demoralising me, on the contrary it helped

me to see myself as I was, warts and all and a deep acceptance of myself took place.

Without realising it, I had been kicking about a piece of crumpled paper. It looked like a dirty piece of cardboard. I was trying to work out how God could possibly accept me and forgive me when I was finding it so difficult to be faithful. Something inside me said, 'pick it up!' I immediately stretched down and reached for this messy piece of crumpled cardboard and unfolded it. I could hardly believe what I saw. It was a beautifully illuminated text such as you find in very old manuscripts. It contained a scriptural message which read "He that cometh to Me in no wise will I cast out'.



Joy welled up within me, it was another little proof in my mind that God was up there watching us all. I was utterly overwhelmed by a sense of God's goodness and walked on with a steadier step, more than ever convinced that God really cares.

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Chapter 24

Art Gallery

As I was thinking along these lines, I got news that my father was being admitted to hospital. I decided to once again head back to Malta and both visit my father and consider what future I could carve out there.

I returned to Malta but with a totally different attitude. My mind was clear and set on building a reliable future. My spiritual life was now part and parcel of my day and gave me a new strength which was obvious to others. They no longer questioned my every move, or if they did, they noticed it made less of an impression.

I stayed at home with dad till he was admitted to hospital where he was to stay for the next six months. My sister, Irene invited me to stay with her and her family and I did so, leaving our house empty.

I still wanted to settle down, to be normal and have a steady relationship in my life. That year, I met someone with whom I thought this would be possible. We seemed to get on well together. Perhaps this was the one. We started dating seriously.

One of my first presents during my school days, was Sir William Orpen's 'Outline of Art'. Even before returning to Malta this time, I had re-kindled my interest in art. My mother, father and eldest sister, were all creative but I had always told people I could not draw for toffees. Now, surprisingly, I found that I could draw and had been doing so prodigiously for some months. I became friendly with a local artist, Raymond Pitre, and started using our empty house in Victoria Avenue, to display his works in a way that both he and I could appreciate them.

Friends started visiting and coming to see what was going on. Raymond's way of painting was bold and innovative and they liked what they saw. He would work with ordinary household paint on canvas and end up with stunningly realistic pieces. As more and more were completed, people liked what they saw and started commissioning him to paint for their hotels or for special places in their homes.

One thing led to another and, before long, I partnered with my friend, Brian Mizzi in opening Malta's very first contemporary art gallery. It was called the 'MAZARON' and was in a two storey building in St. Julians, opposite the Hilton Hotel.

Other local artists, such as Mary DePiro, Chircop and Beryl Diamantino started exhibiting their work with us and our client list was growing. To help things along, we decided to hold a weekly event at the Gallery. We offered Champagne and canapés on the gallery roof every Tuesday. This was a great hit. Everybody who was anybody seemed to hear about it and before long, we were hosting visiting ambassadors, actors, musicians, diplomats and selling well.

On one particular occasion, I nearly lost everything.

I had decided to put on a special exhibition which consisted of 22 paintings by 'Gianni', an Italian artist who

lived and worked in Malta in the 19th century. These were high value paintings so I decided the event needed to be insured.

I phoned my brother-in-law who owned an insurance agency.

"Can you do it immediately," I asked him, "We have already started moving the pieces into the building."

"Don't worry," he said. "I will make sure I do it straight away."

A day or two later, when all the paintings had arrived and were hung in the gallery, I was woken at 2 am by the loud ringing of the telephone.

It was my partner on the phone. He was at the gallery.

"Get over here quickly," he practically shouted down the phone. I could hear the panic in his voice and I sat up abruptly, jumping out of bed. I could hear the rain thundering down outside the window and feared the worst. The flat roofs in Malta occasionally fill up like a swimming pool and if there is any blockage in the drains, the water starts seeping through every crack the summer sun has created. This is what had happened and some water was trickeling down the inside of the gallery.

I rushed over there and found the situation was critical. The roof could have caved in at any minute and many thousands of pounds worth of paintings were in jeopardy.

Colonel Strickland lived only two doors away and we woke him up, asking him if we could bring the paintings to the safety of his house till the danger had passed. He readily agreed and the three of us carried out a desperate rescue, dashing back and forth with covered paintings till they were all secure.

The next morning, when calm had returned, I phoned my brother-in-law to let him know what had happened and

to tell him that there was no damage to the 'Gianni' paintings but some minor damage on some of the other paintings from local artists which I had also included in the exhibition.

"I'm sorry, David. I forgot all about it. I never insured you." There was a few seconds of silence. "Don't worry, he said eventually, "It is my fault. I will personally pay for any damage."

I got off the phone and went back to see the situation. There was no structural damage. We started the clean up in the gallery and got the roof seen to, cleaning drains etc to ensure no repeat performance, then inspected each painting thoroughly. A few hours later, with the help of a little 'touch up' and a quick lick of wall paint, everything was back to normal and the exhibition opened as planned. It was a great success.

The good reputation of the gallery got around. One Sunday, I received a phone call from the ADC to the Governor of Malta, asking me to open the gallery that day for a special visit by Prince Charles and his sister, Princess Anne.

"What today! On Sunday?" I replied "I'm not asking," he said, "I'm telling." I of course agreed. "Keep it private," he said, "this is an unofficial visit." He hung up and I immediately phoned Brian and then Captain Ball of Malta public relations. He, in turn contacted the BBC representatives in Malta.

When I arrived at the gallery, George Borg Olivier, the Prime Minister, was waiting there. My father and George were great friends and met regularly for drinks. "May I come in David?" he said. I was taken aback at his question. "Of course Prime Minister, why would you even need to ask. I'd be honoured!"

He smiled. "Well," he replied, "its not official!"

The TV crew arrived, the Prince and Princess arrived and, all in all, it was a great visit. Nobody mentioned the cameras! We presented them with three of Mary De Piro's paintings, one of them was of the dancer Nureyev.

This event did wonders for the gallery's reputation and things just kept going from strength to strength.

Of course it also helped my own self image but it was not one I was particularly interested in.

I had told Brian that I would run the art gallery for one year only and that time was fast approaching. I could also not shake off the feeling that the gallery was not where the Lord wanted me to be and that thought, quite frankly, had more sway with me now than all the success that was falling into my lap. I had now completely lost interest in it and the calling to do something else was becoming more apparent. I felt that this experience, whilst good, was just a preparation for what was to come in my life. I closed the business while it was still viable and took a job in accounts at the office of a horticultural company while resuming my accountancy studies.

Some time after that, my girlfriend who was working as secretary to Lady Watson, the wife of the High commissioner in Malta asked me to come with her to have tea at the Commissioner's villa in Naxxar. Prince William of Gloucester was the only other guest as well as his equerry who had been at Sandhurst about the same time as I.

It was early afternoon and we sat around the pool talking about the changes in the island and how his cousin, the Queen, had enjoyed living here.

The prince asked me what I was doing and why I was living in Malta. He was intrigued when I told him I was working in the accounts department of the Mediterranean

Flower Products. He asked me if I would be kind enough to do him a favour as he wanted to send a gift to a good friend in the Costa Esmeralda. I assured him I knew nothing very much about bushes but, if he so wanted, I could find out what the most appropriate and beautiful one would be. I noticed Lady Watson was getting very upset as she had been left out of the conversation. She instantly remarked that she would see to it herself. For my part, I was very relieved especially since I realised the Prince's good friend in the Costa Esmeralda was none other than the Karim Khan, then one of the wealthiest men in the world.

This meeting was to stay on my mind for life because of later events in London.

Meanwhile nothing was making much sense to me now in Malta. Pat and I had broken up for one reason or another, a few weeks after becoming engaged. Our relationship was just not meant to be. She moved off to France and met her future husband there and she is now, thank God, happily married.

Life went on, I continued working and studied hard for my next exam but I now planned to return to London as soon as this was completed.

On the day before one of my main exam paper, at about 10.30 in the evening, they brought my father into the house as he had fallen into a ditch. I helped to carry him upstairs, not realising that he had broken his leg. The following morning, the day of my exam, I called for an ambulance which took him into hospital again. Fortunately, I managed to concentrate enough to pass the exam but my father remained in hospital for another long stay.

I stayed in Malta till he had recovered, then I returned to London to see if I could make more sense of it now.

It was several months later, when I was still in London

that I sat watching the news. My interest was peaked as they were covering an air-show where Prince William was taking part, flying his own plane which he often did.

As usual, together with him in the plane was his black Labrador which I had seen in Malta. The plane took off and I watched intently. Having met him personally, I felt drawn into the action, feeling a part of it.

Minutes later, everyone gasped as the plane suddenly nose-dived and came crashing to the ground, killing all its occupants instantly. I was stunned. There he was, a healthy, handsome young man and suddenly, he was no more, his life suddenly ended, snuffed out like a candle.

This incident impacted me at a deep level. It showed me, in a very graphic way, how short and fragile all our lives are and how dependent we are on God. I saw how each moment should be looked on as though it could be our last.

At that moment, something was loosed within me. Another tether had snapped which bound me to my old style of life and to the priority I gave to it.

Like a bird leaving a perch, I took off and flew with even more determination into the unknown. It gave me fresh impetus to 'seek first, the Kingdom of God'. All else seemed irrelevant.